

dSLRs for video?

A J.D Power survey shows that one third buy for shooting video, and each photographer takes an average of 918 shots a month

Another Hallmark holiday?

August 19th, the day Louis Daguerre's daguerreotype was announced as a free gift to the world by the French is celebrated as World Photography Day

begins to obscure details and textures. However, this is evident in 100 per cent crops and not when viewing the image full-screen. ISO 12800 is clearly avoidable, except for emergencies, for the dynamic range takes a nosedive and the noise that was slightly evident all along now becomes blatant, blotting out finer details. Still for a crop sensor, the D7000 performs commendably and there is no doubt that it is much better than the Nikon D300s we tested last year, and better at ISO 3200 and onwards than the Canon 60D and 7D. It wins our Best Buy award for its brilliant mix of performance and price.

Canon EOS 7D: ₹87,995 (body only)

The Canon 7D sits at the top of Canon's range of dSLRs with crop sensors. It has a very solid build, with a magnesium alloy body and a nice rubber grip on top. It feels very solid, but not as chunky as the D300s. Canon nails ergonomics on its head – the 7D has a near perfect control layout and ergonomics. Whether it is selecting focus points, or changing some setting, the 7D is very intuitive to use. The buttons are well spaced and large, and while they have a bit extra

travel, they work well for the most part – the extra travel's good with gloves on. The 19 cross point focussing system is very fast, although some might find the focus points a bit sparse, we feel the focus points don't cover as much of the frame as we'd like – the D7000 has better frame coverage. Both cameras focus equal in accuracy, although the 7D is a little faster in lower light. With a lack of contrast, both systems will "hunt".

The 7Ds menus are detailed, but not as intimidating as the D7000's. Canon has chosen a good bunch of settings, one isn't bogged with extras that will be used once every 5000 shots. The 7D supports CF cards, but misses a trick with only 1 slot. The status LCD is reasonably detailed, while a dedicated video mode and live view button is a nice addition. The one button RAW + JPEG button is useful.

The 7D produces good clean images at base ISOs right up to ISO 400. There is one huge problem however – the 7D struggles with displaying any sort of detail with the colour red, and our red flowers appear flat – there is no texture, and the nuances of the petals get lost when viewing a 100 per cent crop. In fact the

petal edges aren't visible – too soft. At ISO 800, there is a fair bit of noise present in dim conditions, but our test scene with its bright lighting looks clean and largely noise free but textures look softer. The D7000 in comparison is a little more detailed. At ISO 1600, the 7D still manages a clean output, but with textures and details losing their liveliness. However, for small to medium sized prints, the output is acceptable. At ISO 3200, the 7D starts to lose a bit of dynamic range, and noise now becomes clearly visible. However, in comparison, the 60D with the same sensor shows a bit more chroma noise, and had some anomalous bright pixels whereas the 7D is free from this. ISO 6400 isn't the cleanest around, but for a crop sensor it does pretty well. The D7000 preserves more detail, while showing about a similar amount of noise, and is thus better than the 7D at ISO 3200 and more so at ISO 6400.

Olympus E5: ₹85,000 (body only)

The E5 won't win any awards for its looks, but it's extremely well built with a metal body, very rugged. Even the popup flash unit is built of metal – something we've not seen. With support for dual cards, one CF and one SD, the E5 offers good versatility, given that you can configure the card slots in a number of ways.

The E5 is comfortable to hold and the dials within easy reach. Unfortunately, (and here's where Olympus starts to get things wrong), the menu system isn't the most intuitive and it takes a while to get things going. The buttons are small, and not laid out very intuitively, and having directional joystick-like buttons

is typically a no-no for dSLRs in this price segment. The status LCD is reasonably detailed but has a weak illumination lamp. The main LCD isn't good for cameras in this price segment, during live view it flickers – not something that is very conducive for judging composition and lighting before clicking.

The sensor on the E5 is smaller than the regular APS-C sensors on most other cameras. The sensor is a micro 4/3



Olympus E5

meaning it has a crop factor of 2. Thus theoretically, we weren't expecting as much in low light. At base ISOs, the E5 has a good clean output. It is fairly detailed, but misses out on liveliness in highlights. In our test shot, the camera captures texture nicely, and even manages to highlight flaws on the surface of a fruit. There is a very slight amount of noise visible at ISO 400, but it's not unpleasant. With normal viewing, ISO 800 isn't a lot different from ISO 400 – a good thing. There is no extra noise, but a slight loss of sharpness and detail, and a further reduction in dynamic range. Still, the E5 manages some nice highlights.

At ISO 1600 darker materials lose textures, and the black cloth looks flat. There is a bit more noise, but the sensor really struggles to resolve details. ISO 3200 is noisy, with a loss of colour and clarity but is okay for screen size



A 100 per cent crop shot with the D3x. Note the fine texture. The image is as good as your eyes see it